

Refer to the *Instructions* and to the *Guide* documents for a glossary of the key phrases in **bold** and for an explanation of the information required in each section. The *Templates* document provides some text that may be helpful in preparing some of the required appendices.

Replace the **highlighted text** with the appropriate information.

Note that the size of the text entry boxes provided on this form does **not** indicate the expected amount of information; instead, refer to the *Instructions* and to the *Guide* documents in providing the complete information required in each section. Do **not** duplicate information from one text box to another. Do not otherwise edit this form.

Reference number: ERGO/FEPS/111889	Submission version: 1	Date: 2026-03-dd
Name of investigator(s) : Lyndsey Ballantyne Oscar Seip Cassandra Gould van Praag Emma Karoune		
Name of supervisor(s) (if student investigator(s)): N/A		
Title of study: Discovering Hidden Community Leaders		
Note that failure to follow the University's policy on Ethics may lead to disciplinary action concerning Misconduct or a breach of Academic Integrity. By submitting this application, the investigator(s) undertake to: - Conduct the study in accordance with University policies governing: Ethics (http://www.southampton.ac.uk/ris/policies/ethics.html); Data management (http://www.southampton.ac.uk/library/research/researchdata/); Health and Safety (http://www.southampton.ac.uk/healthandsafety/); Academic Integrity (http://www.calendar.soton.ac.uk/sectionIV/academic-integrity-statement.html). - Ensure the study Reference number ERGO/FEPS/xxxx is prominently displayed on all advertising and study materials, and is reported on all media and in all publications; - Conduct the study in accordance with the information provided in the application, its appendices, and any other documents submitted; - Submit the study for re-review (as an amendment through ERGO) or seek FEPS EC advice if any changes, circumstances, or outcomes materially affect the study or the information given; - Promptly advise an appropriate authority (Research Integrity and Governance team) of any adverse study outcomes; - Submit an end-of-study form if required to do so.		

REFER TO THE **INSTRUCTIONS** AND **GUIDE** DOCUMENTS WHEN COMPLETING THIS FORM AND THE **TEMPLATES** DOCUMENT WHEN PREPARING THE REQUIRED APPENDICES.

STUDY DETAILS

What are the aims and objectives of this study?

To create a deeper understanding of the scope, value, and impact of Research Community Management (RCM) work undertaken by Research Technical Professionals (RTPs) within the UK research ecosystem, particularly where this work is informal and unrecognised.

Objectives:

1. To identify and document the types of RCM activities undertaken by RTPs.
2. To explore the competencies and skills associated with RCM work, with particular attention to Community and Outreach competencies within the DIRECT Framework.
3. To examine how a lack of formal recognition and inclusion in job descriptions affects leadership opportunities and career development.
4. To map existing organisations and communities involved in RCM activities to identify actors and engagement opportunities.
5. To generate evidence that will inform the design of a statistically robust and construct-validated survey for the wider UK RTP community.
6. To contribute evidence towards the recognition and professionalisation of RCM as a distinct and essential RTP role.

Background of the study (*a brief rationale for conducting the study*)

Across the UK's Research Technical Professional (RTP) landscape, many individuals informally undertake Research Community Management (RCM) activities, including coordinating open-source contributions and sustaining communities of practice. However, these activities often fall outside formal job descriptions and are undertaken without explicit recognition, time allocation, or institutional support. As a result, essential community leadership within the research ecosystem is fragile, unevenly distributed, and dependent on individual goodwill or privilege.

This lack of formalisation limits incentives and career progression for those undertaking RCM work and may contribute to inequities in who is able to take on such roles. Despite the importance of RCM in sustaining socio-technical research infrastructure, there is currently limited data regarding its scope, competencies, and impact.

This study is therefore necessary to document and better understand RCM activities within the RTP community, generate evidence to inform future survey research, and contribute towards improved recognition and professionalisation of RCM as a distinct and essential RTP role.

Key research question (*Specify hypothesis if applicable*)

Primary research question:

What is the scope, nature, and perceived value of Research Community Management (RCM) activities undertaken formally and informally by Research Technical Professionals (RTPs) in the UK research ecosystem?

Sub-questions:

1. What types of RCM activities are RTPs undertaking that fall outside formal job descriptions?
2. What competencies and skills are required for effective RCM, particularly in relation to Community and Outreach competencies within the DIRECT Framework?
3. How does the lack of formal recognition and institutional support affect leadership opportunities and career progression?
4. What are the perceived benefits and impacts of RCM activities on research communities and the wider research ecosystem?

Study design *(Give a brief outline of the study design and why it is being used)*

This study uses a qualitative research design based on semi-structured interviews with up to 20 Research Technical Professionals (RTPs) who are undertaking Research Community Management (RCM) activities.

Participants will be identified through landscape mapping and through networks including the Software Sustainability Institute and the Society of Research Software Engineering (RSE). Interviews will explore the types of RCM activities undertaken, associated competencies and skills, leadership experiences, and the impact of the lack of formal recognition on career development. Interviews will be conducted remotely and analysed using concurrent and iterative thematic analysis.

A qualitative design is being used because there is currently limited data regarding the scope and nature of RCM work. Semi-structured interviews enable in-depth exploration of participants' experiences, perceptions, and contexts, and allow identification of competencies and themes that can inform extension of the DIRECT Framework and the development of a future statistically robust and construct-validated survey for the wider RTP community.

Work packages:

Work package 1: Landscape mapping

- Initial organisational and team level mapping of RCM landscape.
- Development of database framework for in-depth/dynamic/data driven mapping using publicly available data from SSI fellows and Society of RSE.
- Data collection
- Visualisation/mapping

Work package 2: Qualitative interviews

- Development of study design and pre-registration
- Qualitative interviews
- Thematic analysis
- Report writing

PRE-STUDY

Characterise the proposed participants

Participants are likely to be affiliated with UK universities, research institutes, or national research organisations, and may be engaged with communities connected to organisations such as the Software Sustainability Institute and the Society of Research Software Engineering.

The study will include participants from a range of career stages, institutional contexts, and disciplinary backgrounds to ensure diversity of perspective. Individuals under 18 will not be included. Participation is entirely voluntary.

Describe how **participants** will be approached

The investigators are community leaders and administrators within our target communities (SSI and Society of RSE) therefore recruitment at this stage will be restricted to our currently available contact lists.

Approach will be targeted via mailing lists including placement in regular newsletters, and posts on closed community discussion workspaces such as Slack workspaces.

There will be no open call for participation at this time. Open recruitment calls may be considered at a later date once we have completed characterisation of this sub-sample of the dRTP community.

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Describe how inclusion / exclusion criteria will be applied (if any)

Case	Included	Excluded
Role of individual	Any digital Research Professional (dRTP) Role	Non-dRTP roles
Type of community role	Formal community role - named as Research Community Manager or variation of this title Informal community role - not named RCM role but has leadership or responsibility of a community activity or task in a dRTP community or research community of practice	Does not have formal RCM role or any informal community role Community participation only
Type of organisation	Research or research related organisation	Non-research organisation
Geographic location	UK – based on remit of DisCouRSE project funding	Non-UK
Sector	All sectors included	None
Career stage	Early career research professionals onwards (minimally PhD students or equivalent experience)	Undergraduate or Master's students
Language	Professional competency written and spoken in English, indicated by employment in a UK-based dRTP role	Lack of professional English language communication standard.

Commented [ca1]: Did we say minimally PhD students?

Describe how **participants** will decide whether or not to take part

Participation is on a voluntary basis. Brief details of the research will be included in recruitment communications such as emails and Slack message. The attached

participant information sheet (PIS) will be provided as a link in any recruitment materials, along with the researcher's contact details. Participants will be asked to confirm they have reviewed the PIS and asked questions, if necessary, before proceeding to the mapping consent and data collection.

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Participant Information (Appendix (i))

Provide the **Participant Information** in the form that it will be given to participants as Appendix (i). All studies must provide **participant information**.

Consent Form/Information (Appendix (iii))

Provide the **Consent Form** (or the request for consent) in the form that it will be given to participants as Appendix (iii). All studies must obtain **participant consent**. Some studies may obtain verbal consent (and only present consent information), other studies will require written consent, as explained in the *Instructions, Guide*, and *Templates* documents.

DURING THE STUDY

Describe the study procedures as they will be experienced by the participants

We will advertise the study to contacts who are likely to fulfil our eligibility criteria. Advertisements will contain brief details of the study, link to the PIS and consent form. Where they consent to participate, they will be directed to the WP1 mapping data collection form. At the end of the mapping data collection, they will be asked if they would like to participate in WP1 interviews. If participants indicate a preference to participate in WP2, they will be asked to confirm that they would be able to practically participate in a verbal one-to-one interview with use of any accessibility accommodations available to them if necessary. If participants do not wish to take part in WP2, this will be the end of their involvement in the study. They will be reminded of contact details of the researchers and how to follow up if they have further details regarding their participation.

Where interest in WP2 interviews is indicated, the research team will review the mapping data and determine if that participant will be invited to book an interview, based on building a sample population with a diversity of organisations, career stage, sector, and communities they represent. If selected for interview participant will be sent a link to book a 60-minute online interview. Booking the slot will automatically generate a MS Teams meeting link and calendar invite for the participant. At the allotted time participants will join the MS Teams call where they will be greeted by the interviewer, reminded of the study aims and procedure, and given the opportunity to ask any further questions. Their eligibility and consent will then be reconfirmed before the interview begins.

During the interview participants will be asked a series of up to six questions in a semi-structured format (see attached Interview Script). Participants may be asked to elaborate on answers where this is deemed relevant to clarify responses. At the end of the interview participants will be thanked for their contribution, reminded of contact details of the researchers and how to follow up if they have further details regarding their participation.

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Commented [ca2]: I wonder if that is sufficient for our disability inclusion? Anyone who couldn't participate verbally might be reasonably expected to have a speech-to-text translation device?

Commented [ca2R2]: We could then do a live one, but with translation equipment?

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Identify how, when, where, and what kind of data will be recorded (not just the formal research data, but including all other study data such as e-mail addresses and signed consent forms)

Data for WP1 will include contact information and characterisation of professional profiles including role titles, affiliations and types of activities undertake for the

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community(s) they support. This data will be collected in a form after recruited individuals have consented to participate.

Data for WP2 will include semi-structured interview recordings and transcripts. Questions will probe the nature and scope of community responsibilities undertaken and the impact of recognition of those activities. Interviews will be conducted via MS Teams at a convenient time for the participant. Interviews will take place after participants have been consented for WP2, following invitation after participation in WP1.

Full details of the variables to be recorded for WP1 and WP2, and the methods used to ensure their security, is given in the attached DPA.

Commented [ca4]: Please confirm with Michael / Ben that they're happy for us to attach a DMP, or if they need the full set of variables here.

Participant questionnaire/data gathering methods (Appendix (ii))

As Appendix (ii), reproduce any and all **participant** questionnaires or data gathering instruments in the exact forms that they will be given to or experienced by **participants**. If conducting less formal data collection, or data collection that does not involve direct questioning or observation of participants (eg secondary data or "big data"), provide specific information concerning the methods that will be used to obtain the data of the study.

POST-STUDY

Identify how, when, and where data will be stored, processed, and destroyed

If the Study Characteristic M.1 applies, provide this information in the **DPA Plan** as Appendix (iv) instead and do *not* provide explanation or information on this matter here

Full details of the variables to be recorded for WP1 and WP2, and the methods used to ensure their security, is given in the attached DPA

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STUDY CHARACTERISTICS

(L.1) The study is funded by a commercial organisation: **Yes / No** (delete one)
If 'Yes', provide details of the funder or funding agency *here*.

(L.2) There are **restrictions** upon the study: **Yes / No** (delete one)
If 'Yes', explain the nature and necessity of the **restrictions** *here*.

(L.3) Access to **participants** is through a third party: **Yes / No** (delete one)
If 'Yes', provide evidence of your permission to contact them as (v) in the *Checklist* below.
Do *not* provide explanation or information on this matter *here*.

(M.1) **Personal data** is or *may be collected or processed: **Yes / No** (delete one)
Data will be processed outside the UK: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes' to either question, provide the **DPA Plan** as (iv) in the *Checklist* below. Do *not* provide information or explanation on this matter here. Note that using or recording e-mail addresses, telephone numbers, signed consent forms, or similar study-related **personal data** requires M.1 to be "Yes".

(* Secondary data / "big data" may be *de*-anonymised, or may contain **personal data**. If so, answer 'Yes'.)

Commented [ca6]: This is "yes", as kumu is outside UK

(M.2) There is **inducement** to participants: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes', explain the nature and necessity of the inducement *here*.

(M.3) The study is **intrusive**: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes', provide the **Risk Management Plan**, the **Debrief Plan**, and Technical Details as (vi), (vii), and (ix) in the *Checklist* below, and explain *here* the nature and necessity of the intrusion(s).

(M.4) There is **risk of harm** during the study: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes', provide the **Risk Management Plan**, the **Contact Information**, the **Debrief Plan**, and Technical Details as (vi), (vii), (viii), and (ix) in the *Checklist* below, and explain *here* the necessity of the risks.

(M.5) The true purpose of the study will be hidden from participants: **Yes / No** (delete one)

The study involves **deception** of participants: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes' to either question, provide the **Debrief Plan** and Technical Details as (vii) and (ix) in the *Checklist* below, and explain *here* the necessity of the deception.

(M.6) **Participants** may be minors or otherwise have **diminished capacity**: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes', AND if one or more Study Characteristics in categories M or H applies, provide the **Risk Management Plan**, the **Contact Information**, and Technical Details as (vi), (vii), & (ix) in the *Checklist* below, and explain *here* the special arrangements that will ensure informed consent.

(M.7) **Special category personal data** is collected or processed: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes', provide the **DPA Plan** and Technical Details as (iv) and (ix) in the *Checklist* below. Do *not* provide explanation or information on this matter here.

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(H.1) The study involves: **invasive** equipment, material(s), or process(es); or **participants** who are not able to withdraw at any time and for any reason; or animals; or human tissue; or biological samples: **Yes / No** (delete one)

If 'Yes', provide Technical Details and further justifications as (ix) and (x) in the *Checklist* below. Do *not* provide explanation or information on these matters here. Note that the study will require separate approval by the Research Governance Office.

Technical details

If one or more Study Characteristics in categories M.3 to M.7 or H applies, provide the description of the technical details of the experimental or study design, the power calculation(s) which yield the required sample size(s), and how the data will be analysed, as separate appendices.

CHECKLIST OF DOCUMENTS TO UPLOAD

Please provide the following forms, *naming the files as explicitly* as possible, e.g., "Participant Information", "Questionnaire", "Consent Form", "DPA Plan", "Permission to contact", "Risk Management Plan", "Debrief Plan", "Contact Information", and/or "Technical details" as appropriate. Each document must specify the reference number in the form ERGO/FPSE/xxxx, the document version number, and its date of last edit.

- (i): **Participant Information** in the form that it will be given to **participants**.
- (ii): Data collection method (eg for secondary data or "big data") / **Participant Questionnaire** in the form that it will be given to **participants**.
- (iii): **Consent Form** (or consent information if no **personal data** is collected) in the form that it will be given to **participants**.
- (iv): **DPA Plan**.
- (v): Evidence of permission to contact (prospective) **participants** through any third party.
- (vi): **Risk Management Plan**.
- (vii): **Debrief Plan**.
- (viii): **Contact Information**.
- (ix): Technical details of the experimental or study design, the power calculation(s) for the required sample size(s), and how the data will be analysed.
- (x): Further details and justifications in the case of: **invasive** equipment, material(s), or process(es); **participants** who are not able to withdraw at any time and for any reason; animals; human tissue; or biological samples.

Commented [ca7]: Can we get a copy of a previous submission this from Ben?

Commented [LB7R2]: we only need to provide this if M.3-M.7 or H apply, which they do not. See 'Technical details' above the checklist.
It doesn't look like Ben supplied anything for his either